

Not Less Ambition. More Choice”

RITU ANAND
Former Chief Leadership & Diversity Officer and Senior Vice President—HR, TCS

FOR RITU ANAND, former Chief Leadership & Diversity Officer and Senior Vice President HR at TCS, stepping away from a full-time corporate career after more than three decades was both liberating and unsettling.

“The biggest adjustment was not having to be somewhere or be responsible for something every day. I actually had to learn to live without the pressure of being needed,” she says.

What surprised her was that she did not miss the title. Anand does not see leaving a full-time job as the end of professional contribution. “I discovered that experience doesn’t retire when a job does. I still have curiosity, opinions, energy and a desire to contribute. What has changed is that I am much more selective about where I put them.”

Retirement, for Anand, has therefore not meant stepping away from work. It has meant stepping away from having to work. And that is a very different thing. She now engages with different industries and contributes to people development in varied ways.

Anand believes India Inc. loses more than individual talent when experienced professionals leave full-time roles.

“Someone who has spent several years working in business brings something very different into a classroom,” she says.

Women should prepare for the next phase before leaving their current roles is her belief.

“Do your current job better than you did yesterday. Create a unique space for yourself within the organisation. Make yourself visible. Build relationships outside your immediate workplace,” she says.

Her definition of success has evolved. Earlier, it was closely linked to achievement, responsibility and the scale of the role. Today, impact still matters, but so does agency: the freedom to decide where her energy goes and contribute without needing a designation to confer authority.

For Anand, a good day might mean solving a complex problem, meeting someone she has not seen in a while or making a new friend.

“Not less ambition. More choice.”